

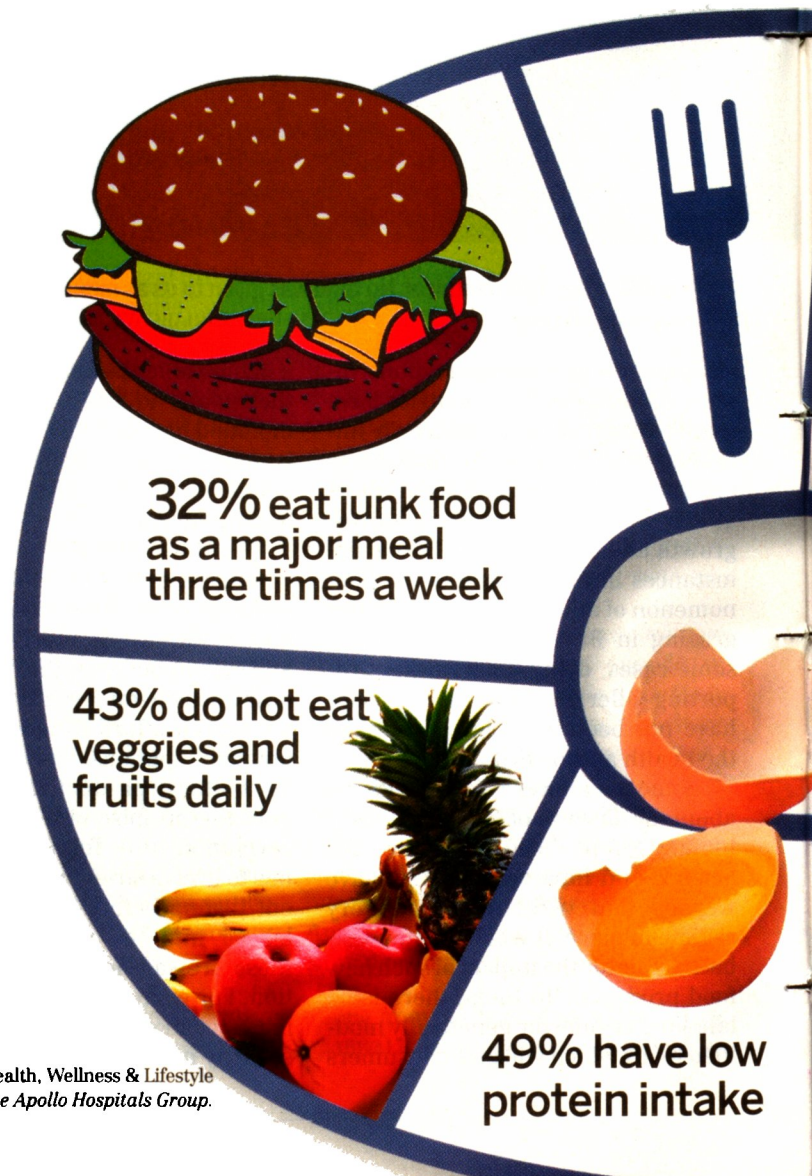
How Healthy is your CHILD?

An exclusive survey of 40,000 schoolchildren across seven states reveals alarming trends about how unhealthy our children really are and a public health crisis in the making

| By Damayanti Datta |

The tummy, they say, is a mirror of emotions. A stick of a girl in the out-patients department of All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS), Delhi, has a stomach issue. In that crowded OPD, where everybody befriends everybody to while away the waiting hours, she sits like a zombie, eyes fixed on the ground. Her parents don't quite know why she gets those excruciating bellyaches. It starts when she is about to go to school and becomes so bad that she is often sent home. Doctors routinely press stethoscopes to her stomach, put her on countless pills, prescribe a battery of tests, before dismissing the pain as a curious, if insoluble, problem. Hazy, drugged and in constant pain, she had to be pulled out of school last month. Today, however, she's in good company. A little down the corridor, Dr Manju Mehta, professor of clinical psychology, and her students are studying precisely this phenomenon—Recurrent Abdominal Pains (RAP)—which they come across increasingly among schoolchildren across the country.

Here's some news that will give parents more reasons to lie awake at night. India's children of prosperity may have much more—clothes, toys, gadgets, sport equipment—than their parents ever did. But with the economic advances of recent years—pumping in new



Source: The School Child Health, Wellness & Lifestyle Survey, 2009, by the Apollo Hospitals Group.